

The Practical Claude Playbook

From Your First Chat to Autonomous Systems (2026)

Why this guide exists

Most people use Claude like a smarter search box. They ask it a question, copy the answer, and move on. That works, and it also leaves about 90 percent of the value on the table.

The people getting real leverage from Claude in 2026 are not better at writing prompts. They understand one thing the casual user does not: Claude is not a chatbot. It is an engine that can read your files, run tools, build deliverables, write and ship code, and do all of it on a schedule while you do something else.

This guide takes you from typing your first question to running systems that do real work without you in the loop. You do not need to code to start, and you will have a clear path for the day you want to go further.

Who this is for

Founders, operators, and business owners who want Claude to actually move the needle, not just answer questions. If you run a company, manage a team, or carry the operational load yourself, this is written for you. No engineering background assumed.

How to use this guide

It is built in three tiers. Jump to where you are.

Tier	You are here if...	You will leave able to...
Part 1 - Beginner	You have used Claude a little, or not at all	Get your first real wins this week and understand the whole landscape
Part 2 - Intermediate	You use Claude regularly but stick to chat	Pick the right tool every time and build workflows you reuse
Part 3 - Advanced	You want Claude doing work unattended	Automate operations and know what is worth building yourself vs handing off

Read Part 1 even if you consider yourself past it. It contains the one mental model that makes everything else in the guide click into place. The whole thing is a 30 to 40 minute read, and it ends with a 30-day roadmap so you do not just learn this, you apply it.

One note on timing. Claude's products move fast. Everything here was accurate as of mid-2026. Where a price or limit matters to a decision, confirm the current number before you commit.

The one idea to take from this entire guide

One engine, many doors.

Anthropic builds the intelligence, the underlying models that do the thinking. Then it ships that same intelligence behind different doors, each one shaped for a different kind of person and a different level of independence.

- The **chat** door is for thinking out loud with a human steering every step.
- The **Claude Code** door is for engineers working inside a codebase.
- The **Cowork** door is for non-technical operators who want work done on their own desktop, no terminal required.
- The **API** door is for developers building Claude into their own products and automations.

Same brain. Different hands. The model answering you in a chat window is the same one refactoring a codebase or building a spreadsheet on someone's desktop.

Once this clicks, every "which tool should I use?" question answers itself. You only ever ask two things:

- 1 Who is doing the work?** You, in the loop? An engineer? A non-technical teammate? Your own software?
- 2 How much autonomy does the task need?** A single answer you review, or a multi-step job that runs on its own?

Hold those two questions in your head as you read. The rest of this guide is just teaching you to answer them well.

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Three levels, thirty sections, one climb.

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What Claude Actually Is (and Isn't)

The foundation every other chapter in this guide stands on.

BOTTOM LINE

Claude is a frontier AI assistant, not a chatbot and not a search engine. It reads, writes, reasons, codes, and can act on your behalf. Once you understand what it is genuinely good at and where it still needs a human, everything else in this guide gets easier.

Start here: it is not a chatbot

Most people meet Claude through a chat box, so they file it next to a search engine or a customer-service bot. That single framing is the biggest reason people underuse it. Claude is a general-purpose AI assistant built by Anthropic, an AI safety company. The same underlying intelligence can draft a proposal, analyze a messy spreadsheet, write and fix software, summarize a 200-page contract, or carry out a multi-step task on your computer while you do something else. The chat box is just the easiest door in.

What Claude is genuinely good at

- **Writing and editing.** Widely considered the strongest of the major models for natural, on-brand writing, long-form drafting, and tightening rough copy.
- **Reasoning and analysis.** It works through multi-step problems, reads long documents, and can explain its thinking. The top models hold up to a million tokens of context at once, roughly several thick books in a single conversation.
- **Coding.** Among the best in the world at writing and fixing software, scoring around 87 percent on a standard real-world engineering benchmark. You do not need to code to benefit from this; we get to that in the Advanced level.
- **Comparative accuracy.** In one 2026 long-form factuality test, Claude made things up far less often than a leading competitor. It is not flawless, but it is relatively careful.
- **Acting, not just answering.** Newer versions can use tools, browse the web, work with your files, and complete tasks, not only return text.

The one idea that unlocks the rest: one engine, many doors

Anthropic builds the intelligence, a family of models, and then ships that same intelligence behind several doors, each shaped for a different person and a different level of independence. The chat website, a desktop app, a phone app, a coding tool, an autonomous desktop agent, and a developer

interface all run the same brain. You choose the door by two things: who is doing the work, and how much you want Claude to act on its own. The next chapters walk through each door. For now, just hold the picture: same intelligence, different hands.

What Claude is NOT

- **Not a search engine.** Claude is trained on data up to a cutoff date, so it does not know today's news by default, though it can search the web when you ask or when that feature is on. Treat it as a reasoning engine, not a live index.
- **Not always right.** It can state wrong things with total confidence, often called hallucination. Verify anything that matters, especially names, numbers, quotes, and sources.
- **Not deterministic.** Ask the same question twice and you may get two different answers. That is normal for this kind of AI, and it is why repeatable, high-stakes tasks eventually get structured. You will see how in later levels.
- **Not a human, and not magic.** It has no memory of you between conversations unless you set that up, no instinct for your business unless you give it context, and no judgment to spare you from checking its work. It is a tool that rewards clear instructions and good context.

WHY THIS MATTERS

The people who get the most out of Claude are not better at writing prompts. They understand what it is, a powerful and context-hungry reasoning engine, and what it is not, an oracle. They feed it context, they verify what matters, and they pick the right door for the job. That is the entire game.

Key takeaways

- Claude is a frontier AI assistant from Anthropic, not a chatbot and not a search engine.
- It is strongest at writing, reasoning over long documents, and coding, and it is comparatively careful with facts.
- One engine, many doors: the same intelligence reaches you through chat, desktop, mobile, a coding tool, an autonomous agent, and a developer interface.
- It has real limits: a knowledge cutoff, occasional confident mistakes, and non-deterministic answers. Give it context and verify what matters.
- Next up: the platforms themselves, and how to pick the right one for what you are doing.

The Claude Universe: Every Way to Use It

Six doors into the same intelligence, and how to know which is yours.

BOTTOM LINE

There is one Claude intelligence, reached through six different doors: the web chat, the Desktop app, mobile, Cowork, Claude Code, and the API. You do not need all of them. This chapter is the map so the next ones make sense.

In Section 1 we said it once: one engine, many doors. Anthropic builds the intelligence and ships it behind several surfaces, each shaped for a different person and a different level of independence. Here is the whole map at a glance, then a short plain-English explanation of each door.

The door	In plain words	Best for
Claude.ai (chat)	Claude in your web browser at claude.ai	Writing, analysis, brainstorming, quick tools
Desktop app	The same Claude as a Mac or Windows app	Daily use, plus one home for Cowork and Code
Mobile	The phone app, and a remote for your desktop	Quick questions and approving tasks on the go
Cowork	An agent that works on your desktop for you	Hands-off file, spreadsheet, and deck work, no code
Claude Code	Claude inside a terminal or code editor	Building and fixing software across a project
API	The developer plumbing behind Claude	Custom apps and automations that run unattended

The six doors, explained

1. Claude.ai (web chat) - the front door

A website where you chat with Claude in your browser. Two features are worth knowing now.

Projects are saved workspaces that remember your context and files, so you are not starting from zero every time. **Artifacts** appear when Claude builds something interactive, like a document, a table, or a small app, and opens it in a side panel you can use and edit. This is where almost everyone starts, and where most of this Beginner level lives.

2. Claude Desktop app - the daily home

The same Claude as a proper app on your Mac or Windows machine instead of a browser tab. It is lighter on your computer than a browser, adds a quick pop-up so you can reach Claude from anywhere, and brings the more powerful modes (Cowork and Code) together in one place. If you use Claude every day, install this.

3. Claude mobile - the companion

The phone app. Good for quick questions on the go, and it doubles as a remote control: you can check on and approve longer tasks that are running on your computer from your phone. Think of it as the companion, not the main workspace.

4. Claude Cowork - the assistant that does the work

Claude as an autonomous assistant that works on your actual desktop. You point it at a folder and give it a goal in plain English, such as "clean up these files," "build this spreadsheet," or "turn this into a slide deck," and it does the work, asking permission as it goes. It is built for non-technical people, with no code or terminal. We give it a full section in the Intermediate level.

5. Claude Code - the builder

Claude inside a developer's environment, a terminal or code editor, that can build and fix software across many files on its own. It sounds technical, and it is the most powerful door, but you do not have to be a programmer to start. It is the heart of the Advanced level.

6. Claude API - the plumbing

Not an app at all. It is what developers use to build Claude into their own products and to run automations that work unattended, with no person watching. You will not touch this as a beginner, but it is good to know it exists. We cover it near the end.

Which door is for me?

Use the same two questions from Section 1:

- **Who is doing the work?** If it is you, thinking and drafting with Claude helping, use the chat (web or Desktop). If you want Claude to go do something on your computer, use Cowork. If it is building software, that is Claude Code. If it is your own app or an automation that runs by itself, that is the API.
- **How much should it act on its own?** Low, where you steer every step, points to chat. High, where it runs and you review, points to Cowork, Code, or the API.

WHERE TO START

Most readers should live in Claude.ai chat and the Desktop app first; they cover the large majority of everyday needs. Add Cowork when you want work done for you, and Claude Code when you are ready to build. That is exactly the climb this guide walks you up.

Key takeaways

- Same intelligence, six doors. Pick by who does the work and how much autonomy you want.
- Start in Claude.ai chat and the Desktop app; they handle most beginner needs.
- Cowork (Intermediate) does desktop work for you, Claude Code (Advanced) builds software, and the API powers unattended automations.
- You can mix doors. A task often starts in chat and graduates to Cowork or Code as you scale it up.

Claude.ai Deep Dive: Your First Real Workspace

Master the main door, the web chat, properly.

BOTTOM LINE

Claude.ai is where almost everyone starts and where most everyday value lives. Learn five things, the interface, file upload, web search, Projects, and Artifacts, and you will already be ahead of most users.

Open a browser and go to claude.ai. This is the web chat app: the simplest, most forgiving door into Claude. It looks like a messaging window, which is exactly why people underuse it. Let us walk through what is actually on the screen and the two features that turn it from a chat box into a workspace.

The interface, in 30 seconds

- **The conversation thread** in the center: you type at the bottom, Claude replies above. Press the new-chat button to start fresh whenever the topic changes.
- **The model picker** near the top lets you choose which version of Claude answers. We cover which to pick in the Intermediate level; the default is fine for now.
- **The attach button** (a paperclip or plus) lets you upload files into the conversation.
- **Web search** can be toggled on so Claude can look things up that are newer than its training.
- **The side panel** opens on the right whenever Claude builds something interactive. That is an Artifact, more on it below.

Uploading files

You can drop in documents, spreadsheets, PDFs, images, and more, then ask Claude to work with them: summarize a long report, pull the key numbers out of a spreadsheet, rewrite a contract clause in plain English, or describe what is in a screenshot. This is one of the fastest ways to get real value on day one. Instead of describing your document, just give it to Claude.

Web search: closing the knowledge-cutoff gap

Remember from Section 1 that Claude has a training cutoff and does not know today's news by default. Turning on web search lets it look up current information and cite where it came from. Use it for anything time-sensitive: recent events, current prices, a company's latest details. Leave it off when

you just want Claude to reason over what you have already given it.

Projects: stop starting from zero

This is the single most valuable beginner feature, and most people never touch it. A **Project** is a saved workspace that remembers its context. You upload reference files once (up to around 20 files), set custom instructions once, and then every conversation you start inside that Project already knows your world. Think one Project per role or per client.

A plain conversation	A Project
Forgets everything once the chat ends	Remembers context across every chat inside it
You re-upload your files each time	Files uploaded once, always available
You repeat your instructions every time	Instructions set once, applied automatically
Best for quick, one-off questions	Best for ongoing work for a role or client

Custom instructions are where you tell Claude who it is for this Project: your brand voice, your role, the format you want, the things to avoid. Set them well and you stop re-explaining yourself in every chat. *(Projects are available on Claude's paid plans.)*

Artifacts: when Claude builds you a tool

When you ask Claude to make something more than text, a formatted document, a table, a chart, a simple calculator, even a small working web page, it opens an **Artifact** in the side panel. You can read it, use it, copy it, download it, and ask Claude to change it right there. It is the difference between Claude telling you how to build something and Claude handing you the finished thing. Try: "Build me a one-page pricing sheet for three packages" or "Make a simple ROI calculator I can fill in."

DO THIS NOW: BUILD YOUR FIRST WORKSPACE

1. Create a Project and name it for a real role or client. 2. Add custom instructions: who Claude is, your voice, what good output looks like. 3. Upload two or three reference files (a brand guide, past work, a key document). 4. Start a chat inside it and ask for something real. Notice that you never had to explain your context. That is the upgrade from search bar to workspace.

Key takeaways

- Claude.ai is the main door: a chat window that is really a workspace.
- Upload files instead of describing them, and turn on web search for anything time-sensitive.
- Projects remember your context, files, and instructions, so you stop starting from zero. Use one per role or client.

- Artifacts hand you finished, editable things (documents, tables, charts, small apps), not just advice.
- Next: how to use Claude on the Desktop app and your phone.

Claude on Your Desktop and Phone

Get Claude off the browser tab and onto every screen you use.

BOTTOM LINE

The browser is fine for trying Claude. The Desktop app is where you should actually live: lighter, always a keystroke away, and the one place the more powerful modes appear later. The phone app keeps you connected and lets you approve work on the go.

The Desktop app: your daily home

The Desktop app is the same Claude, installed as a native application on your Mac or Windows machine instead of running in a browser tab. Three reasons to switch to it:

- **It is lighter and faster.** A browser tab can eat well over a gigabyte of memory. The app uses a small fraction of that, so it stays snappy even when you leave it open all day.
- **It is always a keystroke away.** A Quick Entry pop-up lets you summon Claude over whatever you are working on, ask your question, and dismiss it, without hunting for the right window.
- **It is the one home for everything.** The app brings chat, Cowork, and Claude Code together in a single place, and it can connect to apps and files on your computer. When you reach the Intermediate and Advanced levels, this is where Cowork and Code live.

Get it from claude.ai (look for the download link), install it, and sign in with the same account. Your conversations and Projects follow you automatically.

The phone app: pocket assistant and remote control

The mobile app plays two distinct roles.

- **A pocket assistant.** Quick questions, dictating a draft while you walk, snapping a photo and asking about it, or capturing an idea before it disappears.
- **A remote control.** This is the part most people miss. If you have a longer task running on your computer, such as a Cowork job or a Claude Code session, the phone lets you check on it, answer its questions, and approve its next step from anywhere. The feature for passing tasks between phone and desktop is called Dispatch.

One practical note: approval requests sent to your phone time out after about 30 minutes. It is built for staying in the loop while you step away briefly, not for leaving something hanging for hours.

When to use which

Surface	Reach for it when...
Web (browser)	You are just trying Claude, on a shared or public computer, or you do not want to install anything
Desktop app	It is your daily driver, you want Claude a keystroke away, and you plan to use Cowork or Code
Mobile app	You are on the go, capturing ideas, or checking and approving a task running on your computer

DO THIS NOW

Install the Desktop app and sign in. Trigger the Quick Entry pop-up once so you know the shortcut. Then install the mobile app so you can capture ideas and approve tasks from anywhere. You now have Claude on every screen you use, all sharing the same account, conversations, and Projects.

Key takeaways

- The Desktop app is the daily home: lighter than a browser, a keystroke away via Quick Entry, and the single place where chat, Cowork, and Code all live.
- The phone app is both a pocket assistant and a remote control for tasks running on your computer, through Dispatch. Approvals expire in about 30 minutes.
- Your account syncs across all three surfaces, conversations and Projects included.
- Rule of thumb: web to try it, Desktop to live in, mobile to stay connected.
- Next: how to actually talk to Claude so you get great results every time.

The Beginner's Prompting Playbook

Six moves that make every answer dramatically better.

BOTTOM LINE

Great results do not come from clever wording. They come from briefing Claude the way you would brief a sharp new hire: give it context, tell it exactly what you want, show it an example, and let it ask questions. Master these six moves and you will outperform most people using the same tool.

The biggest mistake beginners make is treating Claude like a vending machine: type a short request, expect a perfect answer. Treat it instead like a brilliant assistant on their first day. It is capable, but it knows nothing about you, your business, or what good looks like until you tell it. These six moves do exactly that.

1. Give it context (the biggest lever)

Before the request, tell Claude what it needs to know: who you are, who the output is for, and any relevant background. The same question with context attached produces a completely different answer. If the context lives in a document, upload it. If it is ongoing, put it in a Project so you never repeat yourself.

2. Ask it to ask you questions first

One line changes everything: "Before you answer, ask me any questions you need to do this well." Instead of guessing and giving you something generic, Claude surfaces the gaps in your request and fills them in. This single habit prevents most bad first drafts.

3. Set the role and the format

Tell Claude who to be ("act as my marketing assistant," "you are a careful financial analyst") and exactly how you want the output (length, structure, tone). "A 120-word friendly email with one call to action" beats "write an email" every time. Vague in, vague out.

4. Show an example

If you have a sample of what good looks like, a past email you liked, a report in the right format, paste it in and say "match this style." Examples teach Claude your taste faster than any description. This is how you stop output from sounding generic.

5. Iterate, do not restart

The first answer is a draft, not a verdict. Stay in the same conversation and steer: "shorter," "more direct," "drop the second paragraph," "make the tone warmer." Claude keeps the context and refines. Starting a brand-new chat throws away everything it just learned.

6. Make it check its work

For anything that matters, add "review your answer for mistakes before finalizing" or "double-check these numbers." Claude is comparatively careful, but it can still be confidently wrong (Section 1). Asking it to verify catches a surprising number of errors, and you still confirm the important facts yourself.

Weak prompt vs strong prompt

Weak	Strong
"Write a marketing email."	"You are my marketing assistant for a boutique accounting firm. Write a friendly cold email under 120 words to small business owners offering a free bookkeeping review, with one clear call to action. Match the voice of this example: [paste]. Before you write, ask me anything you need."

THE REUSABLE SKELETON: R-C-T-F-E

ROLE (who Claude should be) + CONTEXT (the background and files) + TASK (exactly what you want) + FORMAT (length, structure, tone) + EXAMPLE (a sample of good output). Then close with: "ask me questions before you start." Keep this five-part pattern in mind and your prompts write themselves.

Key takeaways

- Brief Claude like a new hire, not a vending machine. Context is the single biggest lever.
- Add "ask me questions first" to almost every real request; it kills generic drafts.
- Set the role and format, and show an example to teach Claude your taste.
- Iterate in the same conversation instead of restarting, and make it check its work on anything important.
- Remember R-C-T-F-E: Role, Context, Task, Format, Example.
- Next: the everyday jobs to put all of this to work on.

10 Everyday Things to Use Claude For

Ten jobs you can hand to Claude this week, with a prompt for each.

BOTTOM LINE

You do not need a grand AI strategy to get value today. Pick a few of these, use the R-C-T-F-E habit from Section 5, and you will save hours this week. Each example prompt is a starting point, add your context and adjust.

1. Triage and draft your inbox

Paste a messy email thread and ask Claude to summarize it and draft a reply in your voice. Prompt: *"Summarize this thread in three bullets, then draft a short, warm reply that proposes a call next week."*

2. Summarize long documents

Upload a contract, report, or PDF and get the essence in seconds. Prompt: *"Summarize this 40-page report in one page, then list the five things I should act on."*

3. Plan a project or break down a goal

Turn a fuzzy goal into a concrete plan. Prompt: *"I want to launch a new service in 6 weeks. Break this into weekly milestones with owners and the first three tasks for week one."*

4. Prep for a meeting

Walk in ready. Prompt: *"I have a call with [company]. Here is their website text. Give me a one-page brief: what they do, likely pain points, and five sharp questions to ask."*

5. Turn rough notes into a clean document

Dump your scattered notes and get something polished back. Prompt: *"Turn these voice-note bullets into a clear one-page proposal with headings."*

6. Research a topic, company, or decision

With web search on, get current, cited answers. Prompt: *"Research the top three competitors in [market], summarize their pricing and positioning, and cite your sources."*

7. Analyze a spreadsheet

Upload data and ask for the story in it. Prompt: *"Here is last quarter's sales data. What are the top three trends, any anomalies, and one chart idea?"*

8. Draft and edit anything

From cold emails to posts to proposals. Prompt: *"Draft three subject-line options and a 120-word email for this offer, then tighten my version below."*

9. Learn something new, fast

Use Claude as a patient tutor. Prompt: *"Explain how [topic] works like I am smart but new to it, then quiz me with five questions."*

10. Make a decision

Pressure-test your thinking. Prompt: *"Here is a decision I am weighing. Lay out the pros and cons, then argue the opposite of what I am leaning toward."*

DO THIS WEEK

Pick three from this list that match a real task on your plate right now. Run them today. The goal is not to use Claude for everything, it is to feel the time it gives back, so the habit sticks.

Key takeaways

- Claude earns its keep on ordinary work: email, summaries, planning, prep, research, analysis, drafting, learning, and decisions.
- Every example here is a template, add your context and tune the format with R-C-T-F-E.
- Start with three real tasks this week, not a master plan.
- Next: the common beginner mistakes to avoid, so these wins keep coming.

The 7 Beginner Mistakes (and the Fixes)

Avoid these and you skip months of frustration.

BOTTOM LINE

Almost everyone who says "AI did not really help me" is making one of these seven mistakes. None of them are about intelligence or wording. They are about habits, and every one has a simple fix you already learned in the last two sections.

1. Blank-chat syndrome

The trap: Starting a fresh chat with no background and expecting Claude to read your mind.

The fix: Give it context first, or work inside a Project that already holds your files and instructions. Context is the single biggest difference between a generic answer and a great one.

2. Vague asks

The trap: "Write something about our service." Vague in, vague out.

The fix: Use R-C-T-F-E from Section 5: spell out the role, the task, the format, the length, and the tone. Specific requests get specific results.

3. Accepting the first answer

The trap: Treating the first draft as the final verdict and walking away disappointed.

The fix: Iterate in the same conversation. "Shorter." "More direct." "Drop the intro." The second and third passes are where the quality actually shows up.

4. No examples

The trap: Describing the style you want instead of showing it, then wondering why it sounds generic.

The fix: Paste a sample of good work and say "match this." One example teaches your taste faster than a paragraph of description.

5. One giant run-on prompt

The trap: Cramming a ten-part request into a single message and getting a shallow answer to all of it.

The fix: Break big jobs into steps, or ask Claude to plan the approach first and then work through it with you. Smaller, clearer steps beat one overloaded prompt.

6. Trusting it blindly

The trap: Copying numbers, quotes, or facts straight into client work without checking.

The fix: Ask Claude to review its own answer, then verify anything that matters yourself. It is comparatively careful, but it can still be confidently wrong.

7. Never using Projects

The trap: Re-uploading the same files and re-explaining your business in every single chat.

The fix: Build a Project once for each role or client. Your context, files, and instructions are then there every time, so you stop starting from zero.

30-SECOND SELF-CHECK

Before you send your next real request, ask: Have I given context? Is the task and format specific? Did I show an example? If the answer is no, fix that first. It takes ten extra seconds and changes the entire result.

Key takeaways

- The complaints about AI almost always trace back to habits, not the tool.
- Context, specificity, and examples fix the majority of weak results.
- Iterate instead of restarting, and verify anything that matters.
- Projects end the start-from-zero loop; use them.
- That wraps the core beginner skills. Next we cover the practical extras: plans, privacy, and the small tricks worth knowing.

Which Plan Should You Start On?

Free, Pro, or Max, in plain numbers.

BOTTOM LINE

Start on Free. The moment you start hitting usage limits or want Opus, Cowork, and unlimited Projects, move to Pro at around 20 dollars a month. That is the right path for the large majority of individuals. Everything else is for heavy users and teams.

First, how usage limits actually work

Claude does not charge per message. Instead, each plan gives you an amount of usage inside a rolling window (commonly a few hours), and then it resets. Free gives you the least; Pro gives you several times more; Max gives you the most. At busy times the limits can tighten a little. The practical translation: if you keep seeing "you are out of messages, come back later," that is your signal to upgrade, not a reason to be frustrated.

The plans at a glance

Plan	Price (approx)	What you get	Best for
Free	\$0	Core Claude, file upload, web search, Artifacts, memory, limited daily use	Trying it and light use
Pro	~\$20/mo	About 5x the usage, all models including Opus, Cowork, unlimited Projects	Most individuals and solo operators
Max	~\$100-\$200/mo	About 5x to 20x Pro usage, full Claude Code, top priority	Power users and heavy daily or coding use
Team / Enterprise	from ~\$25/seat	Shared workspaces, admin controls, larger context, security features	Companies and teams

Free: start here

The free plan is genuinely useful. You get a capable model, file uploads, web search, Artifacts, and memory, enough to work through this entire Beginner level. The only real ceiling is how much you can do in a day. Use it to build the habit before you pay anything.

Pro: the sweet spot for individuals

At roughly 20 dollars a month, Pro unlocks the things that actually change how you work: several times more usage, access to the most capable model (Opus), Claude Cowork, and unlimited Projects. For most owners and operators this is the only upgrade you will ever need, and it usually pays for itself in the first week of saved time.

Max: for power and coding users

Max (around 100 to 200 dollars a month, depending on the tier) gives you far higher usage and full access to Claude Code with top priority. You only need it if you are in Claude all day or doing serious building. If you are not sure you need it, you do not.

Team and Enterprise: for companies

Team plans (sold per seat, minimum a handful of seats) add shared workspaces and admin controls, with a premium tier that includes full Claude Code. Enterprise adds the largest context window, stronger security, and controls large organizations need. Worth knowing they exist; not where a beginner starts.

A NOTE ON PRICES

Claude's plans, prices, and limits change often. The numbers here were current in 2026 and are meant to guide the decision, not to be quoted to the dollar. Always check the live pricing page before you buy.

Key takeaways

- Plans give you usage inside a resetting window, not a per-message charge.
- Free is real and enough to learn on; start there.
- Pro (~\$20) is the upgrade that matters for most people: more usage, Opus, Cowork, unlimited Projects.
- Max is for all-day power users and coders; Team and Enterprise are for companies.
- Prices move, so verify the current page before buying. Next: staying safe and smart with Claude.

Staying Safe and Smart with Claude

Use it confidently on real work, including client work.

BOTTOM LINE

Claude is safe to use on real business work if you follow three rules: do not paste secrets, verify anything you will rely on, and know the handful of tasks where AI is the wrong tool. Get these right and you can trust it with serious work.

1. What is safe to share, and what is not

Treat a Claude chat like a capable contractor you just met. Most of your work is fine to share. A few things are not.

Safe to paste	Keep out (or anonymize first)
Your own drafts, notes, and documents	Passwords, API keys, and other secrets
General business context and strategy	Full customer lists with personal details
Public information and your own data	Regulated data (health, financial, legal) without proper safeguards
Anonymized or sample data	Confidential third-party information you are not allowed to share

When in doubt, strip names and identifying details before pasting, or describe the situation instead of sharing the raw file.

2. How your data is handled (the plain version)

Anthropic is an AI safety company, and privacy is one of its selling points. On personal plans you can control whether your conversations are used to help improve the models, so check your privacy settings and set them the way you want. Business and Enterprise tiers go further, with stronger guarantees including not training on your data at all. If you handle sensitive client work at scale, that is a reason to look at a business plan.

3. Always verify what matters

From Section 1: Claude can be confidently wrong. That is fine as long as you treat its output as a strong draft, not gospel. Before anything goes to a client or into a decision, check the load-bearing parts yourself: names, numbers, dates, quotes, legal or financial specifics, and any citation. Asking

Claude to "review this for errors" first catches a lot, but the final check is yours.

4. Know when NOT to use AI

The most underrated skill is recognizing the wrong job for the tool.

- **Final high-stakes decisions.** Use Claude to research and draft a legal, medical, or tax matter, then have a qualified human make the call.
- **When you cannot verify and the stakes are high.** If you have no way to check the answer and being wrong is costly, do not rely on it.
- **Perfectly predictable, repetitive tasks.** If a job is the same every time (pull this number, move this file), a simple fixed rule is more reliable than a creative AI. More on this distinction in the later levels.

YOUR SAFETY HABITS, IN ONE LINE EACH

No secrets in the chat. Anonymize sensitive data. Set your privacy preferences. Verify anything you will rely on. And keep a human in charge of high-stakes calls.

Key takeaways

- Claude is safe for real work, including client work, with a few sensible habits.
- Never paste secrets; anonymize sensitive or regulated data before sharing.
- Check your privacy settings; business and Enterprise tiers add stronger guarantees.
- Verify the parts that matter, and keep a human in charge of high-stakes decisions.
- Next: the final beginner section, your starter routine and the bridge into the Intermediate level.

Your 7-Day Claude Starter Plan

Turn nine sections of knowledge into a habit in one week.

BOTTOM LINE

Reading this guide will not change anything. Using it will. Here is a simple seven-day plan that puts every beginner skill into practice on your real work. Do one step a day and by next week Claude will be part of how you operate.

Each day builds on the last and ties back to a section you have already read. Keep it light: 15 to 30 minutes a day on tasks you were going to do anyway.

Day	Focus	Try this
1	Set up	Install the Desktop and phone apps. Create a Project for one role or client, add custom instructions, and upload two or three reference files.
2	Brief well	Take one real task and write the prompt with R-C-T-F-E, ending with "ask me questions first." Compare it to how you used to ask.
3	Get wins	Pick three use cases from Section 6 and run them on real work today.
4	Files and search	Upload a long document and ask for a one-page summary plus action items. Turn on web search for one current-info task.
5	Build a tool	Ask Claude to create an Artifact you can actually use (a one-pager, a simple calculator, a checklist) and refine it in place.
6	Make it yours	Improve your Project's instructions (let Claude interview you), and save two or three go-to prompts you will reuse.

7	Review and decide	Tally the time you saved. If you hit limits or wanted Opus or Cowork, upgrade to Pro. Then run the readiness check below.
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THE BEGINNER TOOLKIT, IN ONE BOX

Six doors (chat, Desktop, mobile, Cowork, Code, API). One workspace habit (Projects). One prompt formula (R-C-T-F-E, plus ask-me-questions). One safety rule (no secrets, verify what matters). One upgrade trigger (hitting limits means go Pro).

You are ready for the Intermediate level when...

- You reach for a Project by default instead of a blank chat.
- You brief Claude with context and an example without thinking about it.
- You have a few tasks you now hand to Claude every week.
- You have felt real time come back, and probably moved to Pro.

What the Intermediate level unlocks

Beginner was about using Claude well. Intermediate is about making it work for you. Coming up:

- **Claude Cowork:** hand whole tasks to an agent that works on your desktop.
- **Choosing models:** Opus, Sonnet, and Haiku, and when each one pays off.
- **Building repeatable workflows** and turning them into reusable Skills.
- **Scheduling and routines:** work that runs without you sitting there.

THE SHIFT AHEAD

Everything so far has had you in the driver's seat for every step. The next level begins the move from doing the work yourself to directing Claude to do it. That is where the real leverage starts.

Key takeaways

- Knowledge becomes leverage only when you use it; the 7-day plan makes it a habit.
- One step a day, on work you already have, is enough.
- Keep the one-box toolkit handy: doors, Projects, R-C-T-F-E, safety, upgrade trigger.
- When the readiness signs are true, move up. The Intermediate level shifts you from doer to director.

Meet Claude Cowork

Your autonomous assistant that does the work, not just talks about it.

BOTTOM LINE

Cowork is the moment Claude stops being a chat and starts being a worker. You point it at a folder, give it a goal in plain English, and it plans the work and does it on your computer while you watch or step away. No code, no terminal. It lives in the Desktop app on a paid plan.

What Cowork actually is

In chat, you do the work with Claude helping. In Cowork, Claude does the work and you supervise. It is an autonomous desktop agent built for non-technical people. It became available across all paid plans in 2026. Give it a goal like "turn these receipts into an expense report" or "organize this folder," and it figures out the steps and carries them out on your actual files.

How it works

Cowork runs a continuous plan-to-action loop. You grant it access to a folder, it drafts a plan, breaks it into steps, and then reads, creates, and edits files to get the job done. It can even click around websites and apps when a task needs it. Crucially, it runs inside a sandboxed virtual machine on your computer, so it can only touch the folders you connect, not your whole system.

You control how much rope it gets with two modes. **Ask before acting** (recommended) pauses to show you its plan and waits for approval before it changes anything. **Act without asking** runs straight through, which is faster but riskier. In either mode, it always stops and asks before permanently deleting anything.

Set it up, step by step

- 1 Open the Claude Desktop app and sign in on a paid plan. Cowork is not on the web. Click the Cowork tab in the top mode selector.
- 2 Click "Work in a folder" and choose a directory. Start with one safe, low-stakes folder such as Downloads while you learn how it behaves.
- 3 Pick a permission mode. Choose "Ask before acting" for now so you see and approve each plan before it runs.
- 4 Type your goal in plain English, review the plan it proposes, and click Start. Keep the app open and the computer awake, or the task pauses.

A GOOD FIRST TASK

Point it at your Downloads folder in "ask before acting" mode and try: "Clean up this folder. Group files by type, rename them descriptively by their contents, remove obvious duplicates, and move anything older than six months into an Archive subfolder." Review the plan, approve it, and watch it work. That single run shows you what Cowork is for.

What people use it for

- Organizing messy folders and batch-renaming files
- Turning receipts or images into a formatted expense report
- Building real, working Excel models with live formulas
- Compiling research into an on-brand PowerPoint deck
- Running recurring reports on a schedule (covered in a later section)

Limits to respect

- **Your computer must stay awake and online** with the app open. If it sleeps, the task pauses.
- **It uses up your plan's allowance faster** than chat, since it is doing many steps. Keep an eye on heavier jobs.
- **It does not remember across sessions** unless you work inside a Project.
- **In "act without asking" with web access there is a prompt-injection risk**, where a malicious page tries to hijack the task. Keep "ask before acting" on for anything touching the web or important files.
- **For regulated work**, note that Cowork does not yet carry all the audit and compliance features available elsewhere. Keep sensitive data in mind.

Key takeaways

- Cowork is an autonomous desktop agent: you set the goal, it plans and does the work on your files.
- It lives in the Desktop app on a paid plan, runs in a sandbox, and only touches folders you grant.
- Start in "ask before acting," on a safe folder, with one clear goal.
- Mind the limits: keep the machine awake, watch usage, and stay cautious with web access and sensitive data.
- Next: the real-world Cowork workflows worth stealing for marketing and operations.

Cowork Workflows to Steal

Six real workflows for marketing and operations, ready to copy.

BOTTOM LINE

These are the workflows that make Cowork worth it. Three for marketing, three for operations. Each lists what to connect and the exact prompt to give. Run them in "ask before acting" first, and verify the output before it goes anywhere real.

SET THIS UP ONCE

Two things make every workflow below better. First, open Settings and connect the apps you use (Gmail, Calendar, Drive, Notion, Canva, and others). Second, drop a short "business context" note in a folder, your audience, brand voice, and offers, and tell Cowork to check it for any strategic task. Now Claude works with your context, not from scratch.

Marketing workflows

1. Competitor content scan

What it does: Pulls your competitors' recent posts into one comparison table so you can spot what is working without manual digging.

Connect: A web-scraping connector (or web search).

Prompt: *Find the top three competitor accounts in my niche on Instagram, pull their last five reels with likes, comments, and captions, and put it all in one comparison table with a note on the common themes.*

2. One-asset content repurposer

What it does: Turns a single long piece into a week of platform-ready posts in your voice, then files them for you.

Connect: Notion (or Google Docs) for saving the output.

Prompt: *Here is a YouTube link. Pull the transcript, then write a LinkedIn post, an X thread, and a short blog in my brand voice. Save them all to my Notion content calendar.*

3. Batch graphics in Canva

What it does: Generates a batch of on-brand slides or graphics without you opening the design tool.

Connect: Canva, with a master brand template saved.

Prompt: *Open my brand template in Canva and make ten fresh slides. Give each a different header covering ten tips to grow on LinkedIn, in my brand colors.*

Operations workflows

4. Morning brief and inbox triage

What it does: Acts as a chief of staff: tells you what today looks like and clears the inbox noise.

Connect: Gmail and Google Calendar.

Prompt: *Build my morning brief: list today's meetings, summarize my unread emails, pull out any action items, and draft replies to the three most important ones for me to review.*

5. Monthly financial dashboard

What it does: Reviews your numbers and turns them into a simple visual you can actually read.

Connect: Stripe or your bank, plus Google Sheets or Notion.

Prompt: *Review last month's income and expenses, calculate a simple profit-and-loss, flag anything unusual, and build a one-page chart. Then set this to run on the first of every month.*

6. Automated invoicing

What it does: Generates correct, on-brand invoices in seconds from a template.

Connect: A Project holding your invoice template and business details.

Prompt: *Create an invoice for Acme Co for 10,000 dollars for consulting services this month, using my template, and save it as a PDF.*

Bonus: for old portals or apps with no integration (government forms, legacy CRMs), turn on Computer Use and Cowork will read your screen and fill the forms by clicking, just like a person.

MAKE IT RECURRING

Notice that several of these end with "run this every day" or "every month." That is your bridge to automation. Section 16 shows how scheduling and routines turn any of these into work that happens without you.

Key takeaways

- Connect your apps and add a business-context note once; every workflow improves.
- Marketing: competitor scans, content repurposing, and batch graphics.
- Operations: morning brief and triage, financial dashboards, and invoicing.
- Computer Use handles legacy tools that have no integration.
- Run in "ask before acting," verify, then schedule the winners. Next: choosing the right Claude model for the job.

Choosing Your Model: Opus, Sonnet, Haiku

Same family, three speeds. Knowing which to pick saves time and money.

BOTTOM LINE

Default to Sonnet for almost everything. Reach for Opus only on the hardest, highest-stakes work. Use Haiku when you want speed on something simple. Paying for the biggest model on everyday tasks is the most common way people waste money with Claude.

Remember the spine: one engine, many doors. There is also one family, several models. Claude comes in tiers built for different jobs. You pick the tier in the model selector inside any app, and the right pick depends on how hard the task is, not on always grabbing the most powerful option.

The family

Model	Think of it as	Best for	Speed / cost
Haiku	The fast intern	High-volume, simple jobs: sorting, extracting, quick summaries	Fastest, cheapest
Sonnet	The reliable senior	About 80% of work: writing, coding, analysis, daily tasks	Balanced
Opus	The expert specialist	The hardest 10-15%: deep reasoning, big multi-step jobs, complex analysis	Slowest, priciest
Fable	The marathoner	Rare, multi-day, highly autonomous projects	Ultra-premium

The simple rule

For most owners and operators, the everyday version is three lines: **Sonnet by default. Opus when it is genuinely hard. Haiku when you want speed on something simple.** That alone puts you ahead of most users, who leave it on the most expensive model and never think about it.

The pro version: 70 / 20 / 10

People who run Claude at scale follow a rough routing rule: about 70 percent of tasks on Haiku, 20 percent on Sonnet, 10 percent on Opus. Matching the model to the difficulty of each task, rather than defaulting to the flagship, can cut a heavy monthly bill dramatically. You do not need to be exact. The point is simply to stop using a sledgehammer for every nail.

What it costs (for the curious)

If you ever use Claude through the developer interface, you pay per million tokens of text. As a 2026 snapshot: Haiku is the cheapest, Sonnet sits in the middle with a very large memory, and Opus costs several times more for the toughest reasoning. On a normal chat or Cowork plan you do not pay per token at all, your plan covers it, so there the model choice is about quality and speed, not a direct bill.

A NOTE ON VERSIONS

Claude releases new model versions regularly (the current generation is Opus, Sonnet, and Haiku in their latest numbers, with an ultra tier above). The names and prices shift, but the three-speed logic, fast and cheap, balanced, or maximum reasoning, stays the same. Check the current lineup when it matters.

The mistake to avoid

Defaulting to the most powerful model for everything. It is slower, it burns your allowance faster, and for routine work you usually cannot tell the difference in the output. Save Opus for the moments that actually deserve it, and you get speed, savings, and the same quality where it counts.

Key takeaways

- One family, three speeds: Haiku (fast and cheap), Sonnet (balanced default), Opus (maximum reasoning).
- Everyday rule: Sonnet by default, Opus when it is hard, Haiku for simple speed.
- Pro pattern: roughly 70/20/10 across Haiku/Sonnet/Opus to control cost.
- On chat and Cowork plans you do not pay per token, so choose by quality and speed.
- Do not default to the flagship. Next: connecting Claude to the tools where your work lives.

Connecting Claude to Your Tools

Turn a smart assistant into one that actually knows your business.

BOTTOM LINE

Out of the box, Claude knows nothing about your world. Connect it to the apps where your work lives, email, calendar, docs, Slack, Notion, and it can read your real situation and act on it. This is the step that makes Claude feel less like a tool and more like staff.

Connectors: plug Claude into your apps

A Connector links Claude to one of your accounts so it can see and work with what is there. You turn them on once in Settings, authenticate each app, and they are available in chat and in Cowork.

Connect	And Claude can...
Gmail	Read, summarize, triage, and draft email in your voice
Calendar	See your schedule, plan your day, and find time
Drive / Docs	Pull from and write to your real documents
Slack	Catch you up on channels and summarize long threads
Notion	Read and update your workspace and databases

Claude in Chrome: act on any website

Some work does not live in a neat app with a connector. For that, Claude in Chrome is a browser extension that lets Claude see the page you are on and act on it: fill out a form, pull details off a listing, or carry out a task on a site that has no other integration. Think of it as hands for the open web.

MCP, in plain English

You will hear the term MCP (Model Context Protocol). Think of it as a universal adapter, like USB-C for AI. Instead of someone hand-building a custom link for every app, MCP is one open standard that lets Claude plug into hundreds of tools: databases, CRMs, project trackers, and more. You do not have to build anything. Managed gateways exist that offer a thousand-plus apps you can simply

switch on. Developers go deep on MCP in the Advanced level. Here, just know it is the reason the list of things Claude can connect to keeps growing.

The payoff: a CEO-level read on your week

Once a few tools are connected, you can ask the kind of question that used to take an assistant an hour. For example: *"Read across my Gmail, Calendar, and Notion and give me a CEO-level summary of what is happening this week, plus the three things that actually need my attention."* Claude pulls from all of it and hands you the answer. Connected Cowork workflows (the morning brief, the financial dashboard from Section 12) run on exactly this.

CONNECT SAFELY

Only connect what you are comfortable sharing. You grant access explicitly and can revoke it anytime. Start with read access on one or two apps, see how it feels, and expand from there. The Section 9 safety habits still apply.

Key takeaways

- Connectors link Claude to your real accounts (Gmail, Calendar, Drive, Slack, Notion) so it works from your actual context.
- Claude in Chrome gives it hands on websites that have no connector.
- MCP is the universal adapter behind it all; you switch tools on, you do not build them.
- Connected, Claude can answer business-wide questions and power your Cowork workflows.
- Connect only what you are comfortable with, and start small. Next: turning a repeated task into a reusable Skill.

Build Once, Reuse Forever: Your First Skill

Stop re-explaining the same task. Turn it into a Skill.

BOTTOM LINE

A Skill is a saved workflow Claude can run on demand. Once you build one, you stop walking Claude through the same steps every time and start triggering the whole process by name. It is the clearest example of the doer-to-director shift, and you do not write any code.

What a Skill actually is

A Skill is a reusable instruction pack: a name, a short description of when to use it, and the steps and standards to follow. Once it exists, you trigger it by name, or Claude loads it automatically when your request matches, instead of re-explaining the whole process. It is the difference between giving someone directions every time and handing them a checklist they already know by heart.

The 3x rule: when to make one

Here is the test. If you find yourself walking Claude through the same multi-step task three or more times in a week, that is a Skill waiting to happen. Recurring reports, a standard outreach sequence, formatting a deliverable, your onboarding steps, anything repeatable is a candidate.

How to build one, no code required

You do not write anything technical. Two easy paths:

- **Describe it.** Tell Claude what the workflow does and its steps, and ask it to package that as a reusable Skill. There is an official Skill Creator that will draft, test, and even package it for you.
- **Let it interview you.** Say "interview me about how I do this, then turn it into a reusable Skill." Claude pulls the process out of your head and structures it for you.

What a good Skill contains

- A clear name and a one-line "use this when..." description, so it triggers at the right moment.
- The steps, in order.
- The standards: tone, format, what good looks like, and an example.
- What to avoid.

Keep it lean and specific. A tight, focused Skill beats a bloated one that tries to do everything.

Chaining: skills that feed each other

Skills compose. A "research a prospect" Skill can feed a "write the outreach email" Skill, which feeds a "log it to the CRM" Skill. You stop running steps one at a time and start running a pipeline. This is exactly where Cowork's repeatable workflows come from.

WORKED EXAMPLE: THE WEEKLY CLIENT UPDATE SKILL

Name: "Weekly client update." Use when: every Friday, for each active client. Steps: pull this week's progress from the project doc, summarize wins and blockers, draft a friendly 150-word update in our voice, list next week's priorities. Standard: warm, concise, no jargon, one clear next step. Build it once, run it every Friday in seconds.

Keep them living

A Skill is never truly finished. When you notice weak output, edit the instructions. The best operators treat their Skills as living documents that get sharper every week, which means Claude's output gets better over time, not worse.

Key takeaways

- A Skill is a saved, reusable workflow you trigger by name instead of re-explaining.
- Use the 3x rule: repeat a task three times in a week and it should be a Skill.
- Build it by describing it or letting Claude interview you, no code.
- Chain Skills into pipelines, and keep refining them over time.
- Next: scheduling and routines, so your Skills run without you sitting there.

Scheduling and Routines

Put your best workflows on autopilot.

BOTTOM LINE

Once a workflow is reliable, you should not have to start it by hand. Scheduling lets Claude run your Skills on a cadence, daily, weekly, monthly, and Cloud Routines run them on Anthropic's servers even when your computer is off. This is where the time you save compounds.

Two kinds of scheduling

There are two ways to make work recur, and the difference is simply where it runs.

	Cowork schedule (local)	Cloud Routines
Runs where	On your computer	On Anthropic's cloud
Computer can be off?	No, must be awake with the app open	Yes, runs without you
Best for	Tasks that use your local files	Hands-off jobs while you are away
Triggers	A time schedule	A time, an event, or an API call

Scheduling inside Cowork

The simplest path. Inside an active Cowork task, type **/schedule** and set the cadence (daily, weekly, monthly). It then appears under the Scheduled list in the sidebar, where you can manage or cancel it. The one catch: because it runs on your machine, your computer has to be awake and the app open when it is due. Great for a morning brief while you have coffee; less ideal for 3 a.m.

Cloud Routines: even with your computer off

Cloud Routines fix that. They run on Anthropic's infrastructure, so the job fires whether your laptop is on or not. You set them up from the Scheduled tab in the Desktop app (or the web), give the routine a name, a prompt, and a model, and point it at a place to save its results. They can be triggered on a schedule, by an event, or by an API call. The full agentic loop still runs, so the routine can reason and recover from small errors mid-run.

What to automate (and what not to)

- **Great candidates:** the daily morning brief, a weekly report, the monthly financial dashboard, a daily competitor or trend scan, recurring content drafts. In short, any reliable Skill from Section 15 with clear inputs.
- **Leave manual:** one-off tasks, anything that needs your judgment partway through, and high-stakes actions that should never run unreviewed.

Run them well

- **Mind the caps.** Some plans limit how many routine runs you get per day, around fifteen on certain tiers, so check yours.
- **Write one-shot prompts.** You will not be there to steer, so be specific and cover the obvious edge cases.
- **Keep secrets out** of the prompt itself.
- **Review the run history**, especially early on, and tighten the instructions when something looks off.

STAY HUMAN-ON-THE-LOOP

Automating is not the same as ignoring. The shift is from approving every step to supervising the outcomes: let the routine run, then skim the results and step in only when needed. Check new routines closely for the first week before you trust them in the background.

Key takeaways

- Cowork's /schedule runs recurring work locally; Cloud Routines run it on the cloud even when your computer is off.
- Automate reliable, repeatable Skills with clear inputs; keep judgment calls and high-stakes actions manual.
- Watch the run caps, write specific one-shot prompts, and keep secrets out.
- Supervise outcomes instead of steps, and verify new routines before trusting them.
- That is the Intermediate engine. Next: the section that ties it together and bridges to the Advanced level.

Giving Claude a Memory: Context That Sticks

The skill that separates reliable results from random ones.

BOTTOM LINE

Claude is brilliant but forgetful. The quality of what you get back depends almost entirely on the context you keep in front of it. Learn the three layers of memory and you stop getting inconsistent results and start getting reliable ones.

There is a saying among power users: the model is not king, context is king. Two people using the exact same Claude get wildly different results, and the difference is almost always how well they manage what Claude knows. Here are the three layers to manage.

Layer 1: Working memory (and context rot)

Every conversation has a memory budget called the context window. As a single chat gets very long, or you paste in big documents and go back and forth many times, Claude's focus can drift and its answers get sloppier. This is **context rot**. The fix is simple: keep one chat to one topic, and start a fresh conversation when you switch jobs. You lose nothing if the durable context lives in a Project (Layer 2).

Layer 2: Persistent memory (Projects and the memory feature)

Projects are your main tool for context that lasts. Files, custom instructions, and the thread of past chats all live inside the Project, so every new conversation there already knows your world. Separately, Claude's memory feature can carry facts about you across conversations, your preferences and ongoing work, so you repeat yourself less. Check your settings to see what is on.

Layer 3: Your knowledge base (reference docs)

The most reliable context is the kind you write down once. Keep a small set of reference documents, your brand voice, your pricing, your standard process, and feed the right one into the task at hand. A useful habit: rather than one giant instructions file, keep a short master note that points to smaller, focused docs ("voice is in voice notes, pricing is in the pricing sheet"). Claude pulls in only what each task needs, which keeps it sharp. That index idea is exactly how power users build a full second brain in the Advanced level.

LET CLAUDE BUILD YOUR CONTEXT

Do not write all this from a blank page. Tell Claude: "Interview me about my business, my voice, and how I work, then draft the reference notes and custom instructions for my Project." It pulls the knowledge out of your head and structures it for you, the same interview trick from earlier sections.

Signs of context rot, and the fix

- Answers get vaguer or start ignoring earlier instructions. Fix: start a fresh chat.
- Claude contradicts something it said earlier in a very long thread. Fix: move the durable facts into the Project, then begin again.
- You are re-explaining your context every session. Fix: put it in a Project or a reference doc once.

Key takeaways

- Context is king: results track the quality of what you keep in front of Claude.
- Working memory fills up and rots; keep chats focused and start fresh for new topics.
- Projects and the memory feature hold context that lasts across chats.
- Reference docs, organized with a simple index, are your most reliable memory.
- Let Claude interview you to build it. Next: putting the whole Intermediate toolkit together and stepping up to Advanced.

Build Your Own Assistant

Snap the pieces together into one system that works for you.

BOTTOM LINE

You have now learned every part: context, connectors, skills, Cowork, and routines. This section snaps them into one personal assistant. The framework is four words, the Four C's, and it is the same logic the Advanced level uses to run an entire business on Claude.

The Four C's

Any working assistant needs four things. You have already built each one in this level.

The C	What it means	You built it in
Context	What it knows about you and your business	Section 17 (Projects, reference docs)
Connections	What it can reach and act on	Section 14 (Connectors, Chrome)
Capabilities	What it can do, on demand	Sections 11-12, 15 (Cowork, Skills)
Cadence	When it runs	Section 16 (scheduling, routines)

What it looks like in practice

Picture an operations assistant built from the Four C's, running across one ordinary day:

- **Morning:** a scheduled routine reads your calendar, inbox, and Notion, then sends a brief with the day's priorities and drafts replies to the important emails.
- **Midday:** a content Skill turns your latest idea or voice note into a LinkedIn post and a blog draft in your voice, saved to Notion.
- **Friday:** a weekly routine compiles progress into client updates and a simple revenue snapshot.

All of it uses your context, in your voice, on a schedule. That is not a chatbot. That is staff.

Build it in four steps

- 1 **Context.** Set up one Project with your business context and a few reference docs (voice, offers, clients). Let Claude interview you to write them.

- 2 **Connections.** Connect only the apps it needs to start, usually Gmail, Calendar, and Notion.
- 3 **Capabilities.** Build two or three Skills for your most repeated tasks (Section 15's 3x rule).
- 4 **Cadence.** Schedule the ones that should run on their own (Section 16).

START WITH ONE

Do not build the whole assistant at once. Pick a single workflow, the morning brief is the classic, and get it genuinely reliable. Then add the next Skill, and the next. Your assistant grows one capability at a time, and each one keeps working while you add the rest.

Key takeaways

- An assistant is just the Four C's working together: Context, Connections, Capabilities, Cadence.
- You already built each piece in this level; this is the assembly.
- A real example runs your morning brief, content, and weekly reports automatically, in your voice.
- Build it one workflow at a time, starting with the morning brief.
- Next: managing usage and cost so your assistant stays efficient, then the bridge to Advanced.

Managing Usage, Cost, and Context

Keep your assistant fast, sharp, and affordable.

BOTTOM LINE

Now that Claude is doing real work and running on schedules, a little efficiency goes a long way. Match the model to the task, keep your context lean, and you will hit limits far less often, often without paying for a bigger plan at all.

How usage really works

Recall from Section 8: on a chat or Cowork subscription you do not pay per message. Your plan gives you an amount of usage inside a rolling window that then resets. So "cost" for most readers is not a dollar figure, it is how often you bump into limits. The goal is to get more done inside the same window.

What burns your allowance fastest

- **Very long conversations.** The whole history is reconsidered each turn, so a marathon chat gets expensive and rot-prone.
- **Cowork and routines doing many steps.** Each step costs, so big autonomous jobs are your heaviest consumers.
- **Re-pasting large documents** every session instead of summarizing once.
- **Running the flagship model on everything**, when a faster model would do.
- **Routines firing more often than they need to.**

Token-smart habits

- **Match the model to the task:** Sonnet by default, Opus only when it is hard, Haiku for simple bulk work.
- **Keep chats focused** and start fresh for new topics. This saves usage and fixes context rot at the same time.
- **Summarize big files once**, then work from the summary instead of re-feeding the whole document.
- **Put durable context in a Project** so you are not re-sending it every time.
- **Set routines to the lowest cadence that still works**, daily rather than hourly unless you truly need it.

Upgrade, or just get efficient?

If you hit limits because...	Then...
You are doing genuinely valuable work all day	Upgrade (Pro to Max). The time saved easily covers it.
Your chats are bloated and you run the big model on everything	Fix the habits first. You may not need to pay more.
A few heavy Cowork jobs eat the window	Split them up, run them off-peak, or move to a higher tier.

FOR THE TECHNICAL: EXTRA LEVERS

If you ever build on the developer side, there are deeper cost levers, reusing repeated context cheaply (caching) and running non-urgent work in bulk at a discount (batch jobs). Stacked, these can cut costs dramatically. We cover them in the Advanced level. On a normal plan you do not need them.

Key takeaways

- On a subscription, cost means how often you hit limits; efficiency buys you more room.
- Long chats, heavy autonomous jobs, and the flagship-on-everything habit burn the most.
- Match the model, keep context lean, use Projects, and schedule sensibly.
- Upgrade when the work is genuinely valuable; fix habits when waste is the real cause.
- That completes the Intermediate toolkit. Next: the bridge into the Advanced level.

From Operator to Builder

Recap the Intermediate toolkit, then take the leap.

BOTTOM LINE

You came into this level using Claude. You are leaving it with Claude working for you, connected, skilled, and running on a schedule. The Advanced level is where you stop assembling from features and start building your own systems.

What you can now do

- Hand whole tasks to Cowork and supervise, instead of doing every step yourself.
- Pick the right model for the job, balancing speed, quality, and cost.
- Connect Claude to your real tools so it understands your business.
- Turn repeated tasks into reusable Skills, and chain them into pipelines.
- Schedule work so it runs without you sitting there.
- Manage context so your results stay reliable, not random.
- Assemble all of it into one personal assistant using the Four C's.

THE INTERMEDIATE TOOLKIT, IN ONE BOX

Cowork (the worker). The model rule (Sonnet by default). Connectors (so it knows your business). Skills (the 3x rule). Routines (work that runs itself). Context is king (Projects and reference docs). And the Four C's: Context, Connections, Capabilities, Cadence.

You are ready for Advanced when...

- You have at least one Skill you use regularly.
- You have a Project that holds your real business context.
- You have a workflow running on a schedule.
- You are comfortable supervising Cowork rather than micromanaging it.
- You are curious what becomes possible if you could build your own tools.

What the Advanced level unlocks

Advanced is the power-user level. It is more technical, but it is still built for someone who wants leverage, not someone who wants to become an engineer. Coming up:

- **Claude Code:** the most powerful door, used to build and fix real tools, even if you do not code.
- **Custom workflows and subagents:** orchestrating work at a scale a single chat cannot.
- **Plugins, CLI, and MCP:** extending Claude with the wider ecosystem.
- **Building systems:** agents and automations that run themselves around the clock.
- **The business operating system:** your whole company's context, connections, and cadence in one place.

BEFORE YOU CLIMB

Make sure the assistant from Section 18 is actually running. The Advanced level is more powerful, but the leverage compounds only on a real foundation. One working assistant beats a pile of half-built ones.

THE SHIFT AHEAD

Intermediate was about directing Claude to do the work. Advanced is about building the systems and tools that do the work, turning Claude from your assistant into your infrastructure.

Key takeaways

- You can now run Claude as a connected, scheduled assistant, not just a chat.
- Keep the one-box toolkit handy: Cowork, the model rule, connectors, skills, routines, context, the Four C's.
- When the readiness signs are true, move up.
- Advanced turns you from operator into builder. Get your foundation running first.

Meet Claude Code: The Most Powerful Door

The builder's door, and yes, you can walk through it without being a coder.

BOTTOM LINE

Claude Code is the most capable version of Claude. It can build and change real software and tools across many files, on its own, while you direct it. It looks technical, but the only language you need is plain English. This is where "assistant" becomes "builder."

What Claude Code actually is

Chat helps you think. Cowork does desktop tasks for you. Claude Code goes further: it works inside a project of files, reads and edits them, runs commands, and builds working tools, the way a software engineer would, except you steer it in conversation. It is the most autonomous and most powerful door, running on the top models with a huge memory.

You do not need to be a coder

This is the part that stops people, and it should not. The new reality is that English is the programming language. You describe what you want, and Claude writes and runs the code. Your job is to direct and review, not to type syntax. Treat Claude as an infinitely patient tutor: when it does something you do not understand, ask "what is this?" or "why did you do that?" and it will teach you as you go.

What it can do

- Build a small tool, app, or website from a plain-English description
- Automate a multi-step process across your files and accounts
- Fix, clean up, or extend something that already exists
- Run research, data, and content pipelines that are too big for a single chat

Set it up

- 1 Make sure your plan includes Claude Code (the Max plan gives full access; check current plan support for others).
- 2 Install Claude Code. It runs natively on Windows and Mac, no special setup required. Get it from the official install link.

- 3 Open it inside a code editor like VS Code, or in your terminal. The editor shows your files on one side; Claude lives in the panel where you talk to it.
- 4 Open or create a project folder and sign in with your Claude account.

Your first run

- 1 Point Claude at your project folder and tell it, in plain English, what you want to build or change.
- 2 Run `/init` so it reads the project and writes itself a cheat sheet (you will learn about this file, `CLAUDE.md`, next section).
- 3 Turn on Plan Mode (Shift+Tab) so Claude proposes a plan before touching anything.
- 4 Review the plan, approve it, and watch it work, stepping in whenever you want.

THE GOLDEN RULES FOR NON-CODERS

Do not be an "accept monkey" who approves everything blindly, read what Claude is doing and ask it to explain anything unclear. Always plan before it builds. And work in small steps you can review, rather than one giant request. Curiosity plus caution is the whole skill.

Key takeaways

- Claude Code builds and changes real tools across files; it is the most powerful door.
- You direct it in plain English and review its work; you do not write code.
- It runs natively on Windows and Mac and lives in a code editor or terminal.
- Start with Plan Mode, small steps, and questions; treat Claude as a patient tutor.
- Next: the core concepts that make Claude Code reliable, starting with `CLAUDE.md`.

Claude Code Core Concepts

Five ideas that turn Claude Code from impressive to reliable.

BOTTOM LINE

Claude Code is powerful out of the box and reliable once you understand five things: the CLAUDE.md brain, the context window, permissions, Plan Mode, and a handful of commands. Learn these and you avoid almost every frustration people hit.

A quick mental model first. Think Workflows, Agent, Tools: your plain-language instructions are the **workflow**, Claude is the **agent** (the brain that reads them), and the commands and abilities it uses are the **tools**. Everything below is about steering that loop well.

1. CLAUDE.md: the project's brain

CLAUDE.md is a plain text file at the root of your project that holds Claude's standing instructions. It reads this file before every task: your goals, your rules, the project structure, your preferences. Two rules. Keep it lean, a bloated file wastes the memory budget and confuses more than it helps, so aim well under a couple hundred lines. And if you do not know what to write, run `/init` and Claude drafts one by reading your project. (Later you will use an "index" version: a short CLAUDE.md that points to smaller, focused files.)

2. The context window (and context rot)

Same idea as Section 17, with a twist: in Claude Code, verbose command output, long logs and test results, can flood the context window fast and cause the same drift in quality. The fix is to monitor it. You can have Claude build a custom status line that shows your context usage as a percentage, so you know exactly when to clear or compact before things rot.

3. Permissions and autonomy

By default, Claude Code asks before it edits a file or runs a command, you approve each step. As you build trust on safe work, you can grant more autonomy so it runs without stopping to ask. Only do that on sandboxed, low-risk projects. Never hand full autonomy to something that could touch credentials, money, or important files unsupervised.

4. Plan Mode

Press Shift+Tab to enter Plan Mode. Claude lays out its approach and asks clarifying questions before writing a single line. This one habit prevents most wasted work and runaway costs. Make it your default opening move on anything non-trivial.

5. The essential commands

Command	What it does
/init	Scans your project and writes a starter CLAUDE.md for you
Shift+Tab	Plan Mode: Claude plans and asks before changing anything
/btw	Ask a side question without adding to your context budget
Custom status line	Shows live context usage so you catch rot early
Screenshot loop	Paste a screenshot of the result so Claude fixes the visuals

THE HABIT THAT TIES IT TOGETHER

Lean CLAUDE.md, watch your context, plan before you build, and keep permissions tight until you trust the task. Four small disciplines, and Claude Code goes from a clever toy to a dependable builder.

Key takeaways

- CLAUDE.md is the project brain; keep it lean and let /init start it.
- Watch the context window; verbose output causes rot, a status line keeps you aware.
- Permissions are your safety dial; grant autonomy only on safe work.
- Plan Mode (Shift+Tab) before anything non-trivial saves work and money.
- Learn the core commands. Next: building custom workflows with Skills and subagents.

Creating Custom Workflows: Skills and Subagents

Give Claude Code your own capabilities, and a team to run them.

BOTTOM LINE

Two building blocks turn Claude Code into your own system. Skills are reusable instructions Claude follows. Subagents are extra workers it hands tasks to. Used together, you stop running steps by hand and start directing a small team that knows your standards.

Skills in Claude Code

You met Skills in the Intermediate level. In Claude Code a Skill is simply a markdown file in your project (inside a .claude folder) with a name, a description of when to use it, and the instructions to follow. The clever part is progressive disclosure: Claude only loads the full Skill when your task matches its description, so you can keep dozens of Skills on hand without cluttering its memory.

There are two kinds worth knowing. Some Skills add a **capability** ("design a strong landing page," "run a competitor teardown"). Others encode a **preference** ("always write in our brand voice and never use these words"). Build them by hand, or use the official Skill Creator, which drafts, tests, and packages a Skill from a plain-English description.

Subagents: delegating to a team

For bigger jobs, Claude can delegate to subagents, helper instances that each work in their own fresh context and report back only the result. Picture your main session as a project manager handing tasks to specialists. Set them up with the /agents command, which walks you through it and writes a small config file. Because each subagent starts clean, they keep your main conversation from filling up with raw research or noisy logs, which protects you from context rot on large work.

Subagent best practices

- **Be precise in the description** so the right agent fires at the right time, and not by accident.
- **Give read-only access** when an agent only needs to look, never edit.
- **Route the heavy, simple work to a cheaper model** (Haiku) and keep your main orchestrator on Sonnet or Opus.
- **Only delegate independent, parallel work.** Sequential tasks that depend on shared history should stay in the main thread.

Skill or subagent?

Simple distinction: a Skill is a reusable how-to that Claude follows. A subagent is an extra worker Claude hands a task to. You often combine them, a subagent that follows a Skill, which is exactly how custom pipelines get built.

WORKED EXAMPLE: A RESEARCH-AND-WRITE PIPELINE

A "find prospects" subagent (read-only, on Haiku) gathers leads into a file. Your main session then runs a "write outreach" Skill in your brand voice on each one. A final step logs them to your CRM. Clean context, parallel where it can be, and your standards baked in, all directed by you in plain English.

Key takeaways

- Skills are reusable instructions; in Claude Code they are markdown files loaded only when relevant.
- Skills either add a capability or encode a preference; the Skill Creator builds them for you.
- Subagents are extra workers with clean context that report back results, keeping your main session sharp.
- Delegate only independent work, keep agents tightly scoped, and route simple jobs to cheaper models.
- Combine them into pipelines. Next: orchestrating many agents at scale.

Orchestrating Agents at Scale

From one agent to a swarm, with a clear cost warning.

BOTTOM LINE

Claude Code can run many agents in parallel to tackle huge jobs in a single session. It is genuinely powerful, and genuinely expensive. Use it for big, parallel work, never for simple edits, and always know that the cost can be many times a normal session.

The leap: one agent to many

So far one main session has done the work, delegating the occasional subagent. For truly large jobs, a codebase-wide cleanup, a big migration, deep research across dozens of sources, Claude can orchestrate a whole team of agents working at once. Three tools make this manageable.

Dynamic Workflows and Ultra Code

When a job is too big for one agent, Claude can plan it, spin up many subagents in parallel to handle different pieces at the same time, often have an adversarial "devil's advocate" agent check their work, and merge the results back together. You invoke it with `/workflows`, or use `/ultracode` to let Claude raise its own effort and decide whether a request is complex enough to need the full swarm. This is how people run a codebase-wide bug hunt or a large migration in a single sitting.

Worktrees: run sessions side by side safely

To run several Claude sessions at once without them overwriting each other's files, use git worktrees, isolated copies of your project. One session builds a feature, another fixes a bug, another writes tests, all in parallel and out of each other's way. It is the safe way to multiply yourself.

The dashboard: mission control

When you are running multiple sessions, type "claude agents" to open a dashboard that sorts them into three columns: Needs Input, Working, and Completed. You can peek into any session, reply to it, or close it, and push a running task into the background with `/bg`. It turns a mess of terminal tabs into a single control panel for your agents.

When to use scale, and when not to

Use the swarm for...	Keep it simple for...
Large migrations and refactors	One-file or small edits

Codebase-wide reviews or bug hunts	Anything sequential and dependent
Deep research across many sources	Quick, single-step tasks
Genuinely parallel, independent work	Most everyday jobs

THE COST WARNING (READ THIS)

Every agent in a workflow burns its own tokens. A single dynamic workflow can spawn dozens or hundreds of them and cost many times a normal session, by some accounts up to fifty times more. Reserve this power for big, parallelizable jobs. Running it for a simple edit is how a small task becomes a shocking bill.

Key takeaways

- Dynamic Workflows and Ultra Code spin up many parallel agents for huge jobs, with built-in adversarial checking.
- Worktrees let multiple sessions run side by side without conflicts.
- The agent dashboard ("claude agents") is mission control for parallel work.
- Use scale only for big, parallel jobs; it can cost many times a normal session.
- Next: extending Claude Code with plugins, CLIs, and MCP.

Extending Claude Code: Plugins, CLIs, and MCP

The ecosystem that makes Claude Code do almost anything.

BOTTOM LINE

Three things extend Claude Code: plugins (bundled capabilities), CLIs (fast terminal tools), and MCP servers (the universal adapter to your apps). The ecosystem is enormous. The skill is not installing everything, it is picking a lean stack and adding only what you truly need.

The three ways to extend

Type	What it is	Examples
Plugin	A one-click bundle of skills, rules, and tools	Superpowers, Code-Simplifier
CLI	A fast command-line tool Claude drives from the terminal	GitHub, Playwright, Firecrawl
MCP server	A universal adapter linking Claude to an app or data source	Context7, Composio

Plugins

Installed with the `/plugin` command from a marketplace, plugins package skills, rules, and tools together. A few worth knowing: **Superpowers** (forces a disciplined, test-first process), **Code-Simplifier** (Anthropic's behavior-preserving cleanup, run before you finish), **Security Guidance** (flags risky patterns), **Graphify** (maps your project into a knowledge graph so Claude uses fewer tokens), and the **Codex plugin** (brings in a second AI for adversarial code review).

CLIs

Command-line tools Claude drives directly. Because they live in the terminal right alongside Claude, they are faster and more token-efficient than MCP servers. Must-haves: **GitHub** (push code), **Playwright** (browser automation), **Firecrawl** (web scraping), **GWS** (Google Workspace), and **NotebookLM-CLI** (offload heavy analysis). There is even "CLI Anything," which generates a CLI for almost any program.

MCP servers

The universal adapter from Section 14, now on the builder side. Top servers: **Context7** (injects live, version-correct documentation so Claude does not rely on outdated knowledge), **Composio** (a managed gateway to over a thousand apps), **Firecrawl**, and semantic code-search servers that let Claude find things in a big codebase cheaply.

Where to find them

Use the official plugin marketplace (run `/plugin marketplace add`, or browse the Discover tab in the Desktop app) and the curated "awesome-claude-code" lists on GitHub. Treat those lists as a catalog to learn from, not a shopping spree.

THE GOLDEN RULE: DISCOVER WIDELY, INSTALL SPARINGLY

There are thousands of plugins. A bloated setup slows you down and pollutes context. Start lean: one code-simplifier, one security check, the GitHub CLI, and the one or two MCP servers you actually use. Add something new only when a real need shows up, not because it looked interesting.

Key takeaways

- Plugins bundle capabilities, CLIs are fast terminal tools, MCP servers connect Claude to your apps.
- CLIs are generally faster and cheaper than MCP for the same job.
- Find tools via the official marketplace and awesome-lists; do not bulk-install.
- Run a lean starter stack and grow it only on real need.
- Next: the integration combos that turn these tools into genuine superpowers.

Integration Power-Ups: X + Y = Superpower

Pair Claude Code with one tool and unlock something neither has alone.

BOTTOM LINE

The biggest leaps in capability come from pairings. Connect Claude Code to the right tool and it can scrape the whole web, remember far more than its context window, drive a browser like a human, or build a structured second brain. Here are the four combos worth setting up first.

Each of these builds on a CLI or MCP from the last section. The recipe is always the same: point Claude Code at a specialized tool with a clear goal, and you get a capability the chat could never reach.

1. Claude Code + Firecrawl = scraping at scale

Unlocks: reliable web scraping that gets past anti-bot defenses and JavaScript-heavy sites, returning clean, structured data instead of messy HTML.

Use it for: pulling competitor pricing and reviews, market research on dynamic sites, and enriching a lead list from directories that normally block scrapers.

2. Claude Code + NotebookLM = near-infinite memory

Unlocks: offloading heavy analysis of PDFs, decks, and videos to Google's servers, and storing huge amounts of knowledge for almost no token cost, so Claude can draw on far more than its context window holds.

Use it for: deep research across dozens of documents, generating audio or video assets, and saving whole projects into a searchable knowledge base.

3. Claude Code + Playwright = browser automation

Unlocks: Claude driving a real browser, navigating, clicking, filling forms, and testing logged-in sites, exactly as a person would.

Use it for: automated quality testing of a site you built, or running repetitive web tasks like look-up, click, extract, and summarize.

4. Graphify + Obsidian = a structured second brain

Unlocks: Graphify maps your project or documents into a knowledge graph and exports it as linked notes in Obsidian, giving Claude a structured map it can search cheaply without context rot.

Use it for: navigating a large codebase or document set, and folding everything into one company wiki Claude can reason over.

THE PATTERN IS THE REAL LESSON

These four are the most loved, but do not memorize a list. Learn the move: take a fast tool, give Claude Code a clear goal with it, and combine capabilities. New tools appear constantly; the pairing instinct is what keeps you ahead.

Key takeaways

- Firecrawl gives Claude reliable scraping at scale.
- NotebookLM gives it near-infinite, low-cost memory.
- Playwright gives it real browser control for testing and web tasks.
- Graphify plus Obsidian gives it a structured, searchable second brain.
- The skill is the pairing pattern itself. Next: building systems that run themselves around the clock.

Building Systems That Run Themselves

From tasks you trigger to systems that run around the clock.

BOTTOM LINE

The top of the ladder is work that runs without you. There are three ways to deploy it, an easy hosted path for non-builders, and one rule you must not ignore: real automation belongs on the API, not on a personal subscription.

The three ways to deploy an automation

Method	Runs where	Best for / tradeoff
Local loop (cron)	Your machine	Quick personal automations. Simple, but the machine must stay on.
Cloud routine	Anthropic's cloud	Hands-off recurring jobs, even with your computer off. Has run caps.
External cloud + Agent SDK	Your own cloud account	Production and customer-facing systems. Most control, but real building.

The Agent SDK: the brain plus the hands

The Agent SDK is a toolkit (in Python or TypeScript) that wraps the Claude Code engine so developers can build their own agents without coding the whole loop from scratch. It comes with file access, web search, and tools built in, the brain plus the hands. It is how you put Claude Code's power inside your own product or run it on a cloud server.

Managed Agents: the easy hosted path

If you want cloud-grade automation without the setup, Managed Agents in the Claude Console is a hosted builder. A short guided interface lets you define a task, give it tools and guardrails, pick a model, and deploy to a secure sandbox that you trigger with an API call. It is the fastest way to stand up a reliable background agent.

Guardrails: hooks, permissions, secrets

When agents act on their own, guardrails are not optional. **Hooks** are small scripts that fire on events, before or after Claude acts, so you can block dangerous commands (like reading a secrets file or deleting data), require approval for risky steps, or get pinged when a job finishes. Pair hooks with tight permissions and secrets stored in environment variables, never in the prompt itself.

THE RULE YOU MUST NOT IGNORE

Running automated, unattended work on a personal Pro, Max, or Team subscription violates the terms of service, those plans are for human-in-the-loop use. For real automation, especially anything customer-facing or always-on, build on the API (with the Agent SDK), which is licensed for it and adds proper controls and auditing. Use subscriptions to work with Claude; use the API to build with it.

Key takeaways

- Three deployment paths: local loops (machine on), cloud routines (machine off), and external cloud plus the Agent SDK (production).
- The Agent SDK packages Claude Code's power for your own products and servers.
- Managed Agents is the fast, hosted way to deploy a background agent.
- Guardrails, hooks, permissions, and safe secrets, are mandatory for unattended work.
- Automation runs on the API, not a subscription. Next: tying it all into a business operating system.

The Business Operating System

Where the whole guide converges: a system that runs your operations.

BOTTOM LINE

A business operating system means your context, tools, capabilities, and schedules all live in one place that Claude runs. It is the difference between an assistant that helps with tasks and a system that runs operations. It is built on the same Four C's from Section 18, now at full depth.

The mindset shift that makes it work

The unlock is a change of default: do your work inside Claude (your editor or Claude Code) first, instead of opening a browser and ten apps. Brainstorm, write, research, and plan through it. Everything you do then becomes context the system can reuse. You stop context-switching and start compounding. As the saying goes, the model is not king, context is king, and this is how you feed it.

Architecture: your business as files

Structure your whole company as local files and folders. Because everything is a file, Claude can crawl, search, and organize your entire operation instantly. A typical layout:

- **A context folder:** who you are, your voice, offers, and clients. This is the fuel.
- **A decisions log:** what you decided and why, append-only.
- **Archives:** never delete, move things here.
- **Separate sub-projects** for distinct work (a campaign, a product, scheduled automations) so they do not pollute the main context.

The Four C's at full depth

The C	At the operating-system level
Context	Your business as files: context docs, a decision log, a structured second brain
Connections	Your whole stack wired in via MCP and APIs: email, CRM, payments, calendar
Capabilities	A library of Skills, packaged by domain: a marketing pack, an ops pack, a sales pack

Cadence	Routines and scheduled agents running the recurring work
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The three gaps it closes

- **The memory gap:** a structured second brain (an Obsidian vault organized into raw, wiki, and index) so the system actually remembers.
- **The consistency gap:** Skills, so every task runs to your standard, not to Claude's mood that day.
- **The accessibility gap:** a dashboard or command center on top, so non-technical teammates can trigger the system without ever touching a terminal.

Build it incrementally

Do not build the whole operating system at once. Start with the context folder and one domain pack, say marketing. Wire in one connection. Schedule one routine. Add the next pack when the first is solid. Keep context lean and route work to the right model so it stays affordable. The OS grows the way your business does, one reliable piece at a time.

THE PAYOFF

When it is running, you stop being the bottleneck. The context lives in the system, the standards live in the Skills, the work runs on a cadence, and your team reaches it through a dashboard. That is the difference between using AI and operating on it, and it is the kind of system a partner can help you design if you would rather not assemble it solo.

Key takeaways

- A business OS puts your context, connections, capabilities, and cadence in one place Claude runs.
- It starts with a mindset shift: work inside Claude first so everything becomes reusable context.
- Architect your business as files; use the Four C's as the blueprint.
- It closes the memory, consistency, and accessibility gaps with a second brain, Skills, and a dashboard.
- Build it one pack at a time. Next: the finale, your roadmap and where to go from here.

Claude Code in the Real Business

Three workflows that make or save real money, and that you can sell.

BOTTOM LINE

All this power is only worth it if it shows up in revenue. Three areas where Claude Code earns its keep: building and selling websites, ranking locally, and running content. Each is both internal leverage and a service you can productize.

1. Build and sell websites

- **Stitch to site:** design visually in Stitch, export the front-end code, drop it into Claude Code as your starting landing page, and refine the components. A custom site, fast, not a generic template.
- **Client-ready CMS:** have Claude extract a brand's look (colors, typography) from an inspiration site, generate the site, push it live through GitHub and Vercel, then build a simple dashboard so the client edits their own copy, pricing, and SEO without breaking anything. That is a sellable deliverable.

2. Rank locally (the 50,000-clicks playbook)

- **Optimize the Google Business Profile** using a setup document and real "money keywords" pulled from a tool like Semrush.
- **Auto-post on a schedule**, using voice files (tone, humor, vocabulary) so the posts sound like you, not a bot.
- **Generate service-plus-city pages** (for example, "emergency plumbing Toronto") with keyword clusters so you rank for many nearby searches at once.
- **Fix technical SEO automatically:** run Lighthouse, paste the report into Claude, and let it correct the issues toward a top score.

3. Run a content engine

- **Find content gaps** by scraping competitors' top titles and view counts, then crossing them with your own coverage.
- **Write strong hooks** from your own ideal-customer language library and a swipe file, in visual, spoken, and text versions.
- **Cascade one asset:** feed a single video link and get a LinkedIn post, an X thread, a Reddit post, and a landing page out the other side.

- **Fix carousels:** generate a striking cover with an image model and clean HTML body slides, then tweak them live in the browser.

INTERNAL LEVERAGE, OR A SERVICE

Every workflow here does double duty. Run it for your own business to save time, or package it as a service, a website build, a local-SEO retainer, a content system, and sell it. That is how power users turn Claude Code from a subscription cost into a revenue line.

Key takeaways

- Websites: design in Stitch, build and ship with Claude Code, hand clients a CMS they can edit.
- Local SEO: optimize the profile, auto-post in your voice, build city pages, fix technical issues.
- Content: find gaps, write hooks, cascade one asset into many, and fix carousels.
- Each workflow is both internal leverage and a sellable service.
- Next: the finale, your roadmap and where to go from here.

Your Roadmap From Here

The whole climb in one place, and your next 90 days.

BOTTOM LINE

You started this guide using Claude like a search bar. You finish it knowing how to run an entire operation on it. The only thing left is to climb, one level at a time, on your real work. Here is the map and the plan.

The climb you just made

Three levels, one ladder. Beginner was about using Claude well: the doors, prompting, and daily wins. Intermediate was about making it work for you: Cowork, connected tools, Skills, and routines, assembled into an assistant. Advanced was about building: Claude Code, custom workflows, systems that run themselves, and a business operating system. Each level was the foundation for the next.

THE WHOLE PLAYBOOK IN ONE BOX

Six doors (chat, Desktop, mobile, Cowork, Code, API), pick by who works and how much autonomy. Brief with R-C-T-F-E. Default to Sonnet, Opus when it is hard, Haiku for bulk. Build with the Four C's: Context, Connections, Capabilities, Cadence. Keep context lean, verify what matters, and run real automation on the API. Climb one level at a time.

Your next 90 days

Phase	Focus	Do this
Days 1-30	Use it well	Set up the Desktop app and a Project, master R-C-T-F-E, run the 7-day starter, and get a daily win.
Days 31-60	Make it work for you	Run a Cowork workflow, connect your tools, build two or three Skills, schedule them, and assemble your assistant with the Four C's.

Days 61-90	Build systems	Start Claude Code, build one custom workflow, deploy one automation, and lay the first brick of your operating system.
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Staying current

Claude moves fast: new models, new features, new tools every month. This guide is a snapshot, not scripture. Build one habit of checking what is new every few weeks, revisit the level you are on, and verify any price or feature before you lean on it. The ladder does not change, even as the rungs get better.

The one thing to remember

If you forget everything else, keep this: the model is not king, context is king, and the people who win are not better prompters, they are better at giving Claude what it needs and picking the right door for the job. Do that, and climb one level at a time, and you will be further than almost everyone using the same tool.

WANT IT BUILT FOR YOU?

If you would rather have this designed, wired, and running without assembling it solo, that is exactly what NexusPoint does. Book a free AI automation audit and we will map the single highest-leverage automation in your business and show you what it takes to ship it. ->
<https://nexus-point.co/>

Final word

Reading this changed nothing. Using it changes everything. Pick your level, take the next step today, and let the leverage compound. The search bar is behind you.